

Green Paper 17 — Commons as Habitat

Green Papers: Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship

Status: Working paper (v0.1). Revised over time. · January 2026

A Green Paper on shared life-support systems, local stewardship, and care beyond ownership

Status: Green Paper (living)

1. From resource to habitat

Commons are often described as resources to be managed. This framing already distorts reality.

A resource is extracted. A habitat is lived within.

This paper proposes a shift: **commons as habitat**—the shared conditions that allow life to continue.

2. The mistake of ownership

Ownership freezes relationship.

When land, water, knowledge, or care are owned, they are removed from reciprocal feedback. Responsibility narrows while consequences spread.

Commons resist ownership because life requires **circulation**, not possession.

3. Stewardship as presence

Stewardship is not control. It is **ongoing presence**.

A steward:

- * listens to feedback
- * adjusts behavior
- * remains accountable to living systems

Stewardship ends when presence ends. This keeps power temporary.

4. Ostrom revisited: rules-in-use

Elinor Ostrom showed that commons endure when rules are:

- * local
- * contextual
- * revisable
- * enforced through relationship

Rules-in-use function as **collective nervous systems**—sensing overload and triggering correction.

5. Habitat sets the scale

Habitats have natural scales.

Beyond these scales:

- * feedback weakens
- * repair slows
- * extraction hides

Commons governance must therefore remain small enough to feel consequence.

6. Conflict as signal

Conflict in commons is inevitable.

Rather than suppress conflict, habitat-based governance treats it as information:

- * about boundary breaches
- * about overload
- * about misalignment

Repair follows recognition.

7. Commons and nervous-system love

Commons survive when bodies can regulate.

Overloaded stewards make extractive decisions. Commons governance therefore includes:

- * rotation of responsibility
- * rest as policy
- * limits on exposure

Care for the commons begins with care for bodies.

8. Technology as servant

Technology can support commons by:

- * making feedback visible
- * slowing decision cycles

- * supporting transparency

Technology that accelerates extraction undermines habitat.

9. What commons refuse

Commons refuse:

- * enclosure
- * anonymity
- * scale without accountability

These refusals are not ideological. They are protective.

10. Keeping the commons clean

Commons become polluted when:

- * stewardship becomes permanent
- * rules stop adapting
- * care becomes invisible

To keep commons clean:

- * rotate roles
 - * revisit rules
 - * re-anchor in place
-

Closing

Commons are not things we manage.

They are **places we belong**.

When treated as habitat, commons can endure.

This paper establishes commons as living systems of care. All subsequent papers depend on this framing to avoid enclosure and extraction.

Steward: Lars A. Engberg · Spiralweb Stewardship Association